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China's AI Path | Asia Pacific

Doubao Goes Paid?

In our view, ByteDance's reported introduction of paid tiers for Doubao, China's largest AI chatbot app by MAU, signals that China's consumer AI user education phase is largely complete and the industry is pivoting from user subsidies to commercial sustainability.

What's new? Chinese media reported that Doubao's App Store page now includes a paid service agreement and three paid tiers – Standard at Rmb68/month (US\$10) or Rmb688/year, Enhanced at Rmb200/month or Rmb2,048/year, and Professional at Rmb500/month or Rmb5,088/year. At the time of reporting, the app itself had not yet broadly surfaced these paid options. ByteDance stated that Doubao's free daily-use services remain unchanged, while value-added services are being explored and tested, such as PPT creation, data analysis, and video/film production, which consume more inference time and computing resources than standard chatbot queries.

Our take on Doubao's key motivations and implications for the China AI industry:

1) The most aggressive subsidizer turning to paid memberships is a meaningful industry signal. Doubao has been the most aggressive player in China's consumer AI space – free access and massive marketing spend drove it to 300mn+ MAU. Introducing paid tiers signals that **China's consumer AI user education phase is largely complete, the cost of acquiring new users is rising, and the cost of serving existing users with rising token consumption is also increasing.** By charging for complex workloads while keeping basic chat free, ByteDance is taking a first step toward making Doubao's unit economics work, which is important to justify continued AI capex and building a longer-term monetization roadmap.

2) Pricing confirms prosumer positioning, not mass-market monetization. The Standard plan at Rmb68/US\$10 per month appears somewhat aggressive: it sits modestly above global peers (US\$8/month), above domestic alternatives like Kimi (Rmb49/month) while the Qwen, Yuanbao and Ernie apps remain free, 30%-60% above entry-level tier domestic coding plans, and in-line with ByteDance's own video-generation app Jimeng ([Exhibit 1](#)). The pricing, together with the value-added feature set (PPT, data analysis, video production), makes clear that the target audience is creators and knowledge workers, not Doubao's broader 300mn+ MAU base.

3) Compute cost pressure is the underlying economic driver. With daily token consumption reportedly exceeding 120tn in Mar 2026, maintaining flat free access for heavy workloads is economically unsustainable. The tiered structure effectively asks heavy users to subsidize their own compute. *(Continued)*

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Sensitivity analysis: We refer to US AI chatbots as a benchmark with a paying ratio of 5% in 2025 (50mn subscribers out of ~1bn MAU). Doubao, while the clear MAU leader in China at 345mn as of Mar 2026, is at a much earlier stage of monetization, and consumer willingness to pay for AI subscriptions in China remains largely unproven. We therefore assume a significantly lower paying ratio range of 0.3–3.0%, an MAU range of 345–525mn (reflecting continued user growth from current levels), and an ARPPU of US\$98/year (Standard annual plan). On these assumptions, Doubao's annualized subscription revenue could range from US\$101mn-1.5bn, with the mid-case (1.0-1.5% paying ratio, ~435mn MAU) implying US\$426-684mn, though still modest relative to its core advertising business.

Exhibit 1: Subscription plan comparison

Types	Peer Comparison	Monthly Pricing
Chatbots	US players	Tier-1: US\$8 Tier-2: US\$20 Tier-3: US\$100/200/250
	Doubao (per App Store)	Standard: Rmb68/US\$10 Enhanced: Rmb200/US\$29 Pro: Rmb500/US\$71
	Kimi	Andante: Rmb49/US\$7 Moderato: Rmb99/US\$14 Allergretto: Rmb199/US\$28 Allergro: Rmb699/US\$100
	Zhipu Qingyan	VIP: Rmb49/US\$7 SVIP: Rmb229/US\$33
Coding Plans	ByteDance trae coding plan	Lite: US\$3 Pro: US\$10 Pro+: US\$30 Ultra: US\$100
	ByteDance Fangzhou coding plan	Lite: Rmb40/US\$5.7 Pro: Rmb200/US\$29
	Alibaba Tongyi Lingma coding plan	Pro: Rmb59/US\$8.4 (limited-time free)
	Alibaba Bailian coding plan	Standard: Rmb198/US\$28 Pro: Rmb698/US\$100 Max: Rmb1398/US\$200
	Tencent Codebuddy coding plan	Pro: Rmb58/US\$8.3
	Tencent Hunyuan coding plan	Lite: Rmb28/US\$4 Standard: Rmb78/US\$11 Pro: Rmb238/US\$34 Max: Rmb468/US\$67
	Tencent cloud coding plan	Lite: Rmb39/US\$5.6 Standard: Rmb99/US\$14 Pro: Rmb299/US\$43 Max: Rmb599/US\$86
	Minimax coding plan	Starter: Rmb29/US\$4.1 Plus: Rmb49/US\$7 Max: Rmb119/US\$17
	GLM coding plan	Lite: Rmb49/US\$7 Pro: Rmb149/US\$21 Max: Rmb469/US\$67
Video Generation	Jimeng AI (domestic)	Basic: Rmb69/US\$10 Standard: Rmb199/US\$29 Pro: Rmb499/US\$71
	Kling AI (domestic)	Gold: Rmb58/US\$8 Platinum: Rmb234/US\$33 Diamond: Rmb586/US\$84

Source: Morgan Stanley Research

Exhibit 2: Sensitivity Analysis: Doubao subscription revenue (US\$mn)

Doubao		Paying ratio					
		0.3%	0.5%	1.0%	1.5%	2.0%	3.0%
MAU	345	101	169	338	507	676	1,014
	375	110	184	368	551	735	1,103
	405	119	198	397	595	794	1,191
	435	128	213	426	639	853	1,279
	465	137	228	456	684	911	1,367
	495	146	243	485	728	970	1,455
	525	154	257	515	772	1,029	1,544

Source: Morgan Stanley Research Estimates

Exhibit 3: Sensitivity Analysis: Doubao+Qwen+Yuanbao subscription revenue (US\$mn)

Doubao+Qwen+Yuanbao		Paying ratio					
		0.3%	0.5%	1.0%	1.5%	2.0%	3.0%
MAU	446	131	219	437	656	874	1,311
	476	140	233	466	700	933	1,399
	506	149	248	496	744	992	1,488
	536	158	263	525	788	1,051	1,576
	566	166	277	555	832	1,109	1,664
	596	175	292	584	876	1,168	1,752
	626	184	307	613	920	1,227	1,840

Source: Morgan Stanley Research Estimates

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INDUSTRY COVERAGE: China Internet and Other Services

COMPANY (TICKER)	RATING (AS OF)	PRICE* (05/01/2026)
Eddy Wang, CFA		
Autohome Inc (ATHM.N)	E (02/09/2023)	US\$18.60
Full Truck Alliance Co. Ltd (YMM.N)	O (07/05/2023)	US\$8.61
JD.com, Inc. (JD.O)	U (11/10/2025)	US\$29.96
Kanzhun Ltd (BZ.O)	O (08/04/2021)	US\$13.65
KE Holdings Inc (BEKE.N)	O (03/16/2022)	US\$17.06
PDD Holdings Inc (PDD.O)	O (03/02/2023)	US\$99.72
Vipshop Holdings Ltd (VIPS.N)	E (02/24/2022)	US\$14.52
Gary Yu		
Alibaba Group Holding (BABA.N)	O (02/24/2025)	US\$131.50
Baidu Inc (BIDU.O)	E (05/17/2024)	US\$125.88
Meituan (3690.HK)	O (08/29/2024)	HK\$84.45
Tencent Holdings Ltd. (0700.HK)	O (03/19/2020)	HK\$473.00
Rebecca Xu		
HUYA Inc (HUYA.N)	E (05/16/2024)	US\$3.18

IQIYI Inc (IQ.O)	E (01/19/2023)	US\$1.22
JOYY Inc. (JOYY.O)	E (06/02/2022)	US\$58.85
Weibo Corp (WB.O)	U (05/17/2024)	US\$8.36
Yang Liu		
Bilibili Inc (BILI.O)	O (04/13/2026)	US\$21.95
Kuaishou Technology (1024.HK)	E (07/04/2024)	HK\$44.46
NetEase, Inc (NTES.O)	O (01/08/2025)	US\$117.98
Tongcheng Travel Holdings (0780.HK)	O (01/04/2019)	HK\$17.74
Trip.com Group Ltd (TCOM.O)	O (05/17/2021)	US\$54.22

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* Historical prices are not split adjusted.

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